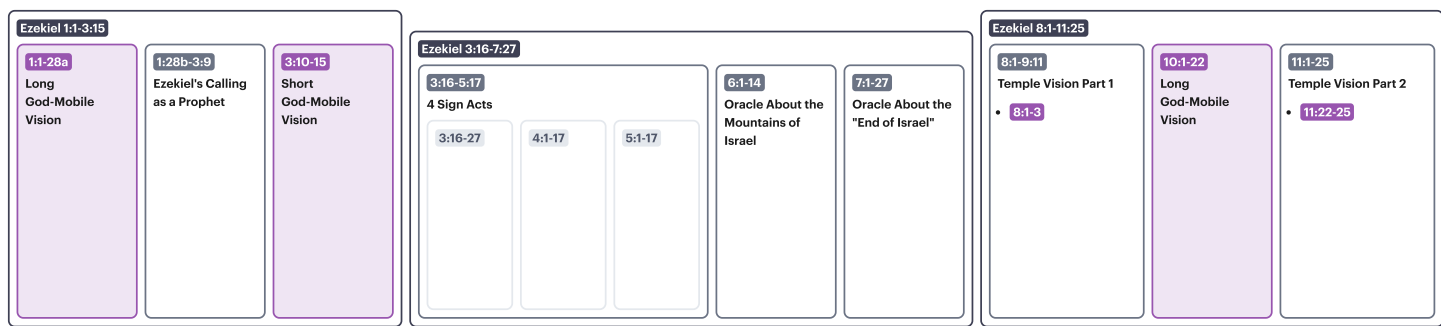


Session 5: Ezekiel's Vision

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel 1-3 is Ezekiel’s commissioning story.
- The phrase “visions of Yahweh” is Ezekiel’s shorthand for divine visions into a realm that is usually invisible.
- The “platform” over the living creatures is a *raqia’*. Elsewhere, this word refers to the expanse of the sky.
- The living creatures, wheels, platform, and throne together present an iconic representation of God’s sky-chariot carrying the mobile temple-presence of Yahweh.

Literary Design of Ezekiel 1-11: Ezekiel’s Vision of Yahweh Leaving and Destroying the Temple



Ezekiel 1:1-11:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Ezekiel 1:1-3:15: Ezekiel’s Vision and Commission

The opening literary unit of Ezekiel’s scroll is an account of his calling to become a prophet to the exiles in Babylon. The composition begins and ends with descriptions of his encounter with the mobile presence of Yahweh, and in the middle is a tightly organized composition that portrays Ezekiel’s commission as a prophet.

Ezekiel 1:1-28a

- A - **1:1** 1st person introduction: date and location of Ezekiel’s vision
- B - **1:2-3** 3rd person explanation: date and location of Ezekiel’s vision
- A - **1:4-28a** 1st person vision of the divine glory

Ezekiel 1:28b-3:9

- **1:28b-2:7** Ezekiel is commissioned to speak on Yahweh's behalf to rebellious Israel
 - **2:4** **"The house of Israel is hard of face and hard of heart."**
 - **2:5** **"I am sending you, whether they listen or resist, for they're a rebellious house."**
- **2:8-3:3** Ezekiel eats the scroll of the divine message for Israel
- **3:4-9** Ezekiel is commissioned to speak on Yahweh's behalf to rebellious Israel
 - **3:7** **"All the house of Israel is hard of forehead and hard of heart."**
 - **3:11** **"You will say to them, 'Thus says Yahweh,' whether they listen or resist."**

Ezekiel 3:10-15

- **3:10-11** God's command to return to the exiles and speak Yahweh's word
- **3:12-14** **Ezekiel is lifted by the Spirit and again sees the divine glory**
- **3:15** Ezekiel returns to the exiles and sits angry for seven days

Ezekiel 1:1-3:15. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 1

1st Person

¹ And it came about in the thirtieth year,
 in the fourth month,
on the fifth of the month,
 that I was **in the midst of the exiles,**
by the river Chebar:
 the skies were opened
and I saw the appearances of Elohim.

3rd Person

² **"On the fifth of the month"**
 This is the fifth year of the **exile** of King Yoyakhin.
 a ³ **The word of Yahweh was**
 b **to Ezekiel son of Buzi the priest**
 c **in the land of Chaldea,**
by the river Chebar,
 a' **and the hand of Yahweh was**
 b' **upon him**
 c' **there.**

1st Person

1:4-14 — The storm cloud and the living beings and their appearance

- A "And I saw a storm cloud coming from the north ... and brightness around it" (v. 4)
"the appearance of glowing metal in the middle of the fire" (v. 4)
"the [living beings'] appearance was like coals of fire" (v. 13)

1:15-21 — The wheels beside the living beings

B

1:22-28a — The throne platform above the living beings and the human-like figure upon it

- "and I saw brightness around him ... like a rainbow in a cloud" (v. 28)
A' "and I saw the appearance of glowing metal like the appearance of fire" (v. 27)
"[the human-like one's] appearance was like fire" (v. 28)
"And I saw and I fell on my face" (v. 28)

Ezekiel 1:1-28a. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021)

4 And I saw, and look:

- A a storm wind was coming from the north,
a great cloud,
and fire was flashing back and forth
and brightness was around it,
and from its middle was like the appearance of a glowing-object ,
from the middle of the fire .

5 And from its middle was the likeness of four the living-beings ,
and this was their appearance:

Human

- a Each had a human likeness,

Face/wing

- b 6 and four faces for each one
and four wings for each one of them,

Legs

- 7 and their legs were straight,
B c and the bottom of their feet was like the bottom of a calf's foot,
and they were glowing like the appearance of polished bronze.

Human

- a' 8 And the hands of a human were under their wings on their four sides.

Face/wing

And the faces and the wings for the four of them,

h'

9 the wings were touching one another,

Movement

- c' they did not turn as they went,,
each one moved in the direction of its face.

Face/human

10 And as for the likeness of their faces:

The face of a human,

- a and the face of a lion was on the right of each of the four of them,
and the face of an ox was on the left of each of the four of them,
and the face of an eagle was on each of the four of them.

Wings

11 And their face and their wings were spread out above:

- b Each one had two touching each other
and two were covering their bodies,

Movement

- 12 and each one moved in the direction of its face,
c' to wherever the spirit/breath would move, they moved;
they did not turn as they moved.

13 And as for the likeness of the living-beings ,
their appearance was like coals of burning fire ,
like the appearance of torches .

A' It was flashing back and forth between the living-beings ;
and there was brightness to the fire
and from the fire there came out lightning .

14 And as for the creatures, there was a rushing and turning back like the appearance of lightning .

a 15 And I saw, the living-beings and look:
one wheel on the ground beside the living-beings , for their four faces.

b 16 The appearance of the wheels and their workmanship
was like the appearance of Tarshish stone;

a' and the four of them had a one likeness.

b' And their appearance and their workmanship
was as if the wheel was in the middle of a wheel.

a 17 When they moved,

b they moved to four of their sides;
they did not turn when they moved.

A

18 And they had rims and height,
and I saw them and their rims were full of eyes/facets around the **four** of them.

- a 19 **And when** the living-beings moved,
b the wheels moved beside them;
a' **and when** the living-beings rose from the ground,
b' the wheels rose up.

B'

- a 20 **Wherever the** spirit/breath moved,
b they moved to where the spirit/breath moved,
b' **and the wheels** rose beside them,
c **because the** spirit/breath of the living-being was in the wheels.

- a 21 **When they moved,**
b they would move;
a' **and when they stopped,**
b' they stopped,
a'' **and when they rose from the ground,**
b'' the wheels rose from the ground beside them,
c **because the** spirit/breath of the living-being was in the wheels.

22 **And over the heads** of the living-being was the likeness of a platform,
like the appearance of fear-inspiring crystal,
spread out over their heads above.

- 23 **And under the** platform
their wings were straight, each to the other;
for each one, **two were covering them,**
and for each one, **two were covering** their bodies.
24 And I heard the sound of their wings,
like the sound of many waters,
like the sound of the Almighty when they moved,
the sound of commotion,
like the sound of an army camp,
when they stood still, their wings dropped.
25 And there came a sound,
from above the platform that was over their heads;
when they stood still, their wings dropped.

26 **And over the** platform that was over their heads,

- a like **the appearance** of **a sapphire stone**,
- b was **the likeness** of a **throne**.
- b' And over **the likeness** of the **throne**,
- a' was **the likeness** like **the appearance** of **a human** on it above.

- a 27 **And I saw** something like a **glowing-object**,
- b like **the appearance** of **fire** was its frame all around,
- c from **the appearance** of **his loins** and upwards.
- c' And from **the appearance** of **his loins** and below,
- b' **I saw** like **the appearance** of **fire**,
- a' and **bright light** all around it.

28 Like **the appearance** of **the rainbow** which is in a cloud on a rainy day,
such was **the appearance** of the light all around.
This was **the appearance** of **the likeness** of **the glory of Yahweh**,

and I saw [framing link back to 1:1]
and I fell upon my face.

Ezekiel 1:4-28a. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021)

Vision of Yahweh's Cosmic Throne-Chariot

The "30th year" is most likely a reference to Ezekiel's birthday and the year that he would have been installed as a priest in Jerusalem (see Num. 4:3, 35). The editorial note in verse 2 coordinates Ezekiel's birthday with the five-year mark since King Jehoiachin's imprisonment and exile from Jerusalem in 597.

This vision happens in 592 while Ezekiel sits by a "river" (נהר) or irrigation canal near his labor camp settlement with the exiles (named Tel-Abib, see Ezek. 3:15). What a horrible place to be on your birthday!

Ezekiel 1:1 Instructor's Translation

... the skies were opened, and I saw visions of *Elohim*.

"The skies were opened ..." Ezekiel is not transported into the skies (as he will be in Ezek. 40:1-3), but he is granted an apocalyptic vision of the divine throne room like the visions experienced by Moses and the elders (Exod. 24:9-11), Micaiah ben Imlah (1 Kgs. 22:19-22), and Isaiah (Isa. 6:1-10).

"Visions of *Elohim*" (מראות אלהים) could be interpreted as "a vision of *Elohim*," that is, a vision of the divine presence. However, this phrase is used two more times in Ezekiel. Once to describe his virtual tour of the Jerusalem temple (Ezek. 8:1-3), where he does see the divine presence, but primarily he is shown the idolatry happening in the temple. The second use of the phrase occurs with Ezekiel's final temple vision, (Ezek. 40:1-3), where he sees the divine glory (Ezek. 43:1-11), but is also shown many other things. "Visions of *Elohim*" is more likely an "attributive construct phrase," which means the second word describes an attribute of the first word. Ezekiel is allowed "divine vision" to see reality from a divine perspective.

Flow of the Vision and Ezekiel's Commission

The vision begins with a storm (Ezek. 1:4) and ends with Yahweh on his throne (Ezek. 1:26-28). These two points of the vision coordinate two key themes of Yahweh's presence from earlier Israelite traditions.

1. Yahweh's appearance at Sinai in cloud and storm (Exod. 19:20; Ps. 18:7-14, Ps. 29).
2. Yahweh's presence in the tabernacle/temple enthroned on a platform above the cherubim in light and glory (Exod. 25:17-22, 40:34-48; Lev. 9:23-24; Isa. 6; Ps. 99:1).

The vision advances in three steps.

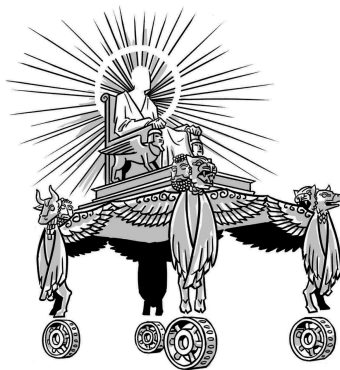
Step 1 (1:4-14): The Storm, the Four Creatures, and Their Appearance

Ezekiel first sees a storm cloud full of fire, from which emerge the four creatures. The appearance of Yahweh in "a storm" (סערה) cloud is a foundational motif in the Hebrew Bible, with its roots in the Eden and Sinai narratives.

In Eden (Gen. 3:8-10), after the humans act foolishly, the "voice/sound" (קול) of Yahweh appears "walking about" the garden with the "wind of the day" (רוח היום).

At Mount Sinai, Yahweh appears in a violent storm complete with sounds, lightning, and earthquake (Exod. 19:16-19, 20:18-20).

These appearances set the pattern for the rest of the Hebrew Bible, where Yahweh's appearance in the storm becomes a motif symbolizing the day of reckoning, either positive or negative. See the use of this Hebrew word סערה with similar associations in 2 Kings 2:1, 11; Job 38:1, 40:6; Isaiah 29:6; Jeremiah 23:19; Zechariah 9:14.



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Guardian creatures (called "cherubim" in Ezek. 10:20) attend Yahweh's presence (see Gen. 3:24; Isa. 6), and now they are repurposed as throne-chariot bearers.

Each creature was common in ancient Near Eastern temple architecture. These hybrid creatures are a symbol of (1) all creatures of the land merged together into one "living creature," and (2) they are category-breaking creatures. They transcend the Bible's organizational categories of creatures into air, land, and sea creatures.

They are called by various titles in the Hebrew Bible (“the heavenly host” in 1 Kgs. 22:19-22; “*seraphim*” in Isa. 6:1-4; “*keruvim*” in Gen. 3:24; Ezek. 10; etc.) and function as guardians of the boundary between Heaven and Earth, specifically in locations that are heavy with Eden-symbolism (mountains, sacred trees, rivers).

In Ezekiel’s vision, they function as throne-bearers, similar to their role described in the phrase “Yahweh who sits enthroned over the *keruvim*” (1 Sam. 4:4; Isa. 37:16; Ps. 80:1, Ps. 99:1).

The fact that there are four creatures with faces pointed in the four directions of the compass is symbolic of the entire cosmos. The same symbol of four directions of the compass is used again in phrases like “the four winds” (Ezek. 37:9, 42:20; Zech. 2:6, 6:5; Dan. 8:8; 11:4).

The various creatures invite reflection on their unique traits and symbolic meaning: human (*imago dei*, wisdom), lion (strength), ox (fertility, agriculture), eagle (swift, mobile).

Step 2 (1:15-21): The Wheels Attached to the Creatures

The motif of Yahweh’s appearance in the storm, where he rides a chariot of *keruvim*, is known elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible.

Psalm 18:9-12 NASB

⁹ He bowed the heavens also, and came down with thick darkness under his feet.

¹⁰ **He rode (רכב) upon a cherub and flew;** and he sped upon the wings of the wind.

¹¹ He made darkness his hiding place, his canopy around him, darkness of waters, thick clouds of the skies.

¹² From the brightness before him passed his thick clouds, hailstones and coals of fire.

When David describes the ark of the covenant, first described in Exodus 25, he explicitly calls it a “chariot” (1 Chron. 28:18, מרכבה).

Exodus 25:17-22 Instructor's Translation

¹⁷ You shall make an atonement-lid of pure gold, two and a half cubits long and one and a half cubits wide.

¹⁸ You shall make two cherubim of gold, make them of hammered work at the two ends of the atonement-lid. ¹⁹ Make one cherub at one end and one cherub at the other end; you shall make the cherubim of one piece with the atonement-lid at its two ends.

²⁰ **The cherubim shall have their wings spread upward, covering the atonement-lid with their wings** and facing one another; the faces of the cherubim are to be turned toward the mercy seat. ²¹ You shall put the atonement-lid on top of the ark, and in the ark you shall put the testimony which I will give to you.

²² There I will meet with you; and from above the atonement-lid, from between the two cherubim which are upon the ark of the testimony, I will speak to you about all that I will give you in commandment for the sons of Israel.

1 Chronicles 28:11, 18-19 Instructor's Translation

¹¹ Then David gave to his son Solomon the plan of the porch of the temple, its buildings, its storehouses, its upper rooms, its inner rooms and the room for the atonement-lid.

¹⁸ ... also his plan for **the golden chariot of the cherubim** that spread their wings and covered the ark of the

covenant of the LORD. ¹⁹ “All this he made clear to me in writing from the hand of the LORD, all the work to be done according to the plan.”

The four wheels on four corners constitute a chariot; the vocabulary used is similar to the bronze wheeled stands in Solomon’s temple (see [1 Kgs. 7:27-37](#)).

Each wheel is described as a “wheel within a wheel” ([Ezek. 1:16](#)). This is not an ancient UFO sighting! The wheels are standard chariot mobile design. This phrase is either describing (1) an outer wheel with an inner wheel joining the spokes or (2) another wheel of same size perpendicular at 90 degrees to the first, creating an optical illusion symbolizing the throne-chariot’s ability to move in any direction without turning (see Assyrian lamassu statue for optical illusions to symbolize movement).

Further, it says “their rims were full of eyes” ([Ezek. 1:18](#)). The word for “eye” (Heb. *‘ayin* / עֵין) can refer to an actual eyeball, in which case this is a symbol for the creatures and wheels as “all-seeing” as the divine presence travels about the cosmos (see the image’s similar meaning in [Rev. 4:6](#)). The word can also mean “facet,” a shining side of a carved jewel or crafted item (see [Zech. 3:9](#)), in which case this is a description of the wheels as sparkling like a faceted jewel.

Ezekiel 1:20 Instructor’s Translation

... the spirit of the living creatures was in the wheels.

The *ruakh* is their animating energy. The creatures and even the wheels are “alive” with a divine energy because of their proximity to the divine presence. This repeated phrase emphasizes the harmonized and unified movement of the wheels and the creatures, even though they are not joined by an axle. This is a rich symbol of how vitalizing and animating the divine presence is, that even inanimate objects like wheels spring to life when they are in the proximity of the creator!

Step 3 (1:22-27): The Platform and Throne Above the Creatures

The platform that Ezekiel sees is called the “sky-dome” (Heb. *raqia’* / רַקִּיעַ), the solid partition that separates the waters above from the waters below in day two of [Genesis 1:6-8](#), which is otherwise called “the skies.”

The image of Yahweh sitting on top of the sky-dome that consists of the waters above is a core image of Yahweh’s sovereignty over the biblical cosmos.

Psalms 29:3, 10 Instructor’s Translation

³ The voice of the LORD is **over the waters**; the *Elohim* of glory thunders, Yahweh is over many waters.

¹⁰ Yahweh sits enthroned **over the flood**; Yahweh is enthroned as King forever.

Exodus 24:9-11 NASB*

⁹ Then Moses went up [Mount Sinai] with Aaron, Nadab and Abihu, and seventy of the elders of Israel,

¹⁰ and they saw the God of Israel; and under his feet there appeared to be **a pavement of sapphire, as clear as the skies themselves**. ¹¹ Yet he did not stretch out his hand against the nobles of the sons of Israel; and they saw God, and they ate and drank.

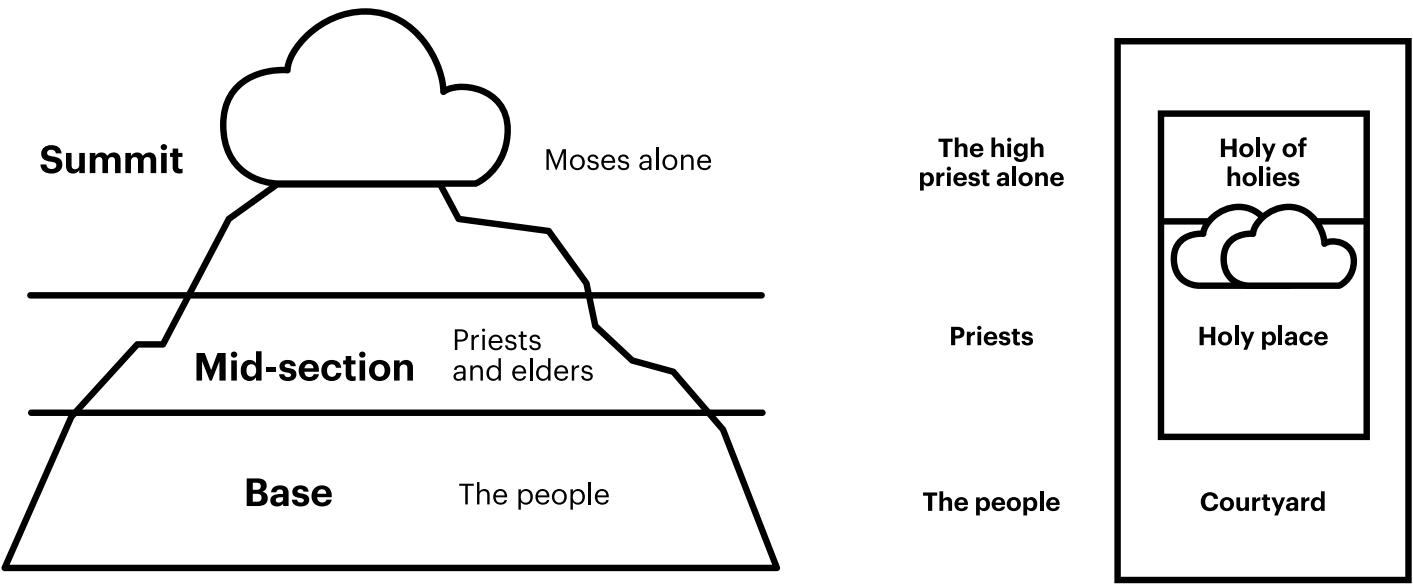
*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These connections all depend on the foundational conception of reality in the Hebrew Bible: that the entire cosmos is a temple, and that Israel’s holy spaces are a microcosmos—a symbolic condensation of the entire cosmos. The set of correspondences is first explored in the creation and Eden narratives of Genesis.

Tabernacle/Temple	Cosmic Geography in Genesis 1:1-2:3	Cosmic Geography in Genesis 2:4-3:24
Holy of holies	The skies	Cosmic mountain / The middle of the garden
Holy place Menorah/Palm trees Cherubim Priests	The land Fruit trees Animals Humans	The garden in Eden Fruit trees Cherubim Humans
Courtyard Bronze sea (<u>1 Kgs. 8:64</u>)	The waters	The land outside the garden

Cosmology of Genesis 1 and 2. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

And then on Mount Sinai, this three-tiered conception of the cosmos is also applied to the mountain.



Sinai and the Temple Reflect the Three-Tiered Cosmos. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Ezekiel’s description of the "God-mobile" uses symbols that are well-known from ancient Near Eastern temple iconography. And while his vision has adapted these symbols in a unique way, there is a strong, shared cultural framework that forms Ezekiel’s visual imagination for the divine presence.

Ezekiel 1:28 Instructor's Translation

... this was the appearance of the likeness of the glory of Yahweh. ...

Glory (*kavod*): weight, significance, often the physical manifestation of significance (see [Exod. 33:18-23, 40:34-35](#); [Lev. 9:23-24](#)).

Notice that this temple-microcosmic imagery is similar to what Isaiah experiences in his prophetic call-vision of [Isaiah 6](#). Notice that instead of the temple *kavod* coming to Ezekiel, Isaiah is transported in a vision to the holy place looking up into the holy of holies, where he learns that “all the land is the fullness of his *kavod*” ([Isa. 6:3](#)).

Reflection Question

Ezekiel describes a vision of four living creatures and four wheels upholding a platform with a throne above. What does this composite image represent in the biblical imagination?